



Identifying Pain Points

Week 1 • Day 4 • Customer-Centric Foundations

Technical Product Manager Academy



Day 4 Objectives

- Extract pain points from observed behavior, not just stated complaints
- Use **5 Whys** to reach root-cause pain
- Group raw pains into themes via **affinity mapping**
- Score pains on **Severity × Frequency × Addressability**
- Distinguish *pains we must fix* from *pains we must live with*



Today's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:15	Opening	Persona pains → pain-point candidates
09:15 – 10:30	Block 1 + Activity 1	Extraction from evidence
10:45 – 12:00	Block 2 + Activity 2	5 Whys + affinity mapping
13:00 – 14:15	Block 3 + Activity 3	Severity × Frequency × Addressability
14:30 – 16:00	Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts	Prioritization + must-live-with

Block 1 — Extraction

Where real pain hides



Where Pains Actually Live

Source	What you see	Reliability
Support tickets	Failures serious enough to complain about	High for severity, low for frequency
Interviews	Stated frustrations, with emotion	Medium; confirmation bias risk
Observation / ride-alongs	Workarounds, sighs, side-channels (paper, shared spreadsheets)	Highest for real pain
Analytics drop-offs	Where users quit a flow	High for "what," silent on "why"
Sales/loss reviews	Why deals didn't close	Medium; filtered through sales narrative

The best pain points are the ones customers *don't complain about anymore* — because they built a workaround.

◆ A Pain Is a Verb

✗ Too vague

- "Bad UX"
- "Inefficient workflow"
- "Training problems"
- "Integration issues"

✓ Actionable

- "Dispatchers retype parts from paper tickets nightly"
- "Mid-day re-routes require calling 3–4 techs individually"
- "New dispatchers bounce from training after screen 5"
- "Truck inventory is off by end-of-week; no one notices until payroll"

Activity 1 — Extract From the Packet

Triads • 45 minutes

Your triad receives the FieldPulse **Pain Extraction Packet** — 8 support tickets, 2 ride-along note pages, 4 interview excerpts, 1 analytics screenshot.

- Extract at least 15 candidate pains
- Each pain must be a verb + circumstance + consequence
- Tag source (ticket #, interview initials, observation) for every entry



10 min read • 25 min extract • 10 min review for verb/vagueness

Block 2 — Root Cause & Themes

5 Whys + affinity mapping



The 5 Whys, Used Well

Take a pain. Ask "Why does that happen?" Take the answer, ask "Why?" again. Five levels deep (usually fewer) you hit a root cause that is either **systemic** or **out of scope**.

```
L1: Dispatchers close books 45 min after shift end.  
Why? They reconcile paper tickets from the day.  
L2: They reconcile paper tickets.  
Why? Techs submit paper (not mobile) tickets.  
L3: Techs submit paper.  
Why? The mobile app is slow on 3G in the field.  
L4: Mobile app is slow on 3G.  
Why? Ticket submission downloads all open jobs first.  
L5: (Root cause – addressable) – Ticket submission is not  
designed for intermittent connectivity.
```

Affinity Mapping in 3 Moves

1. **Silent sort:** Each triad member places every pain on the wall (or whiteboard tool).
No talking.
2. **Cluster:** Group related pains. Name each cluster with a *verb phrase*, not a category.
3. **Promote:** For each cluster, choose 1–2 pains that best represent the whole.

Silence matters: The silent-sort step prevents the loudest voice from anchoring the map. Protect it.

Activity 2 — Dig, Sort, Promote

Triads • 50 minutes

Using your Activity 1 pain list:

- Pick 3 pains that feel "surface-level" — run 5 Whys on each
- Do the silent sort on the full list
- End with 5–8 named clusters, each with 1–2 promoted representative pains



20 min 5 Whys • 20 min silent sort • 10 min cluster + promote

Block 3 — Severity × Frequency × Addressability

How to say no to real pain



The Three Axes

Axis	Question	Scale
Severity	How bad is it when it happens?	Low (annoyance) → Medium (workaround) → High (blocked)
Frequency	How often does it happen?	Low (monthly+) → Medium (weekly) → High (daily)
Addressability	Can we fix it?	Low (org/regulatory) → Medium (partial) → High (fully within product)

Addressability is the axis PMs forget. High severity + high frequency + low addressability = we must communicate, not engineer.

Visualizing the Triangle

Plot each promoted pain in a 3×3 matrix (Severity down × Frequency across), then color-code by addressability.

Sev ↓ / Freq →

Low

High

High

Monitor

Must fix

Low

Accept

Automate / polish

Addressability colors: green = we can amber = partial red = out of scope

A red "Must fix" cell is a **communication problem**, not a product problem.
Those need stakeholder framing, not JIRA tickets.

Activity 3 — Score Your Map

Triads • 45 minutes

Place each promoted pain on the 3×3 matrix. Use evidence tiers from Day 1 when judging severity and frequency — don't guess.

- For every **red "Must fix"** pain, draft 2 sentences: "Why we cannot solve this" + "What we will do instead"
- Identify one pain where AI-augmented analysis could raise addressability (e.g., summarizing inbound to reduce support burden)



20 min place · 15 min addressability notes · 10 min AI-leverage

Block 4 — What We Take Forward

Top 3 pains → Friday's problem statement



Selecting the Top 3

Each triad picks the **three pains** that will drive Friday's problem statement.

The selection must defend:

1. Why these three over the others? (Matrix position + evidence)
2. Are they *independent*, or aspects of the same root cause?
3. What's the single "if we solved this, everything else is easier" pain?

Tip: A great top-3 is often rank-ordered such that #1 unblocks or reduces #2 and #3. If your three feel unrelated, look again for the shared root.

Activity 4 — Cross-Triad Challenge

Paired triads • 60 minutes • Readouts

Each triad presents Top 3 + matrix to another triad. Partners must:

- Nominate the **weakest** of the three (not based on feel — based on the evidence tag)
- Propose one pain they *didn't* select that might be stronger, with reasoning
- Ask one "so what if we're wrong?" question per pain

After critique: 15 minutes to revise. Each triad readouts its final Top 3 in under 60 seconds.



20 min per direction • 15 min revise • 10 min readouts



Day 4 Wrap

What we built

- A scored pain-point matrix per triad
- A Top 3 pain set, rank-ordered and defended
- Language for "pains we must live with"

What opens tomorrow

- **Data-driven problem framing** — turning Top 3 into a problem statement an engineer can scope
- Friday afternoon: integrated Week 1 readouts

Bring to Day 5: Your Top 3 pain sheet with evidence tiers + the one pain you dropped that you're still wrestling with.

Questions & Reflection

Which pain will you re-interview next week?